expanded common ground between Beijing and New Delhi in resisting him on Iranian issues.

Trump's withdrawal of the United States from the JCPOA brought the European powers into the political arena in partnership with Iran in an effort to save the agreement from being destroyed by America. As demonstrated earlier, during negotiation of the JCPOA in the several years prior to its July 2015 signature, China had been an active partner of the United States in persuading Tehran to come to terms over its nuclear programmes. China's role at that juncture was significant, and Xi Jinping's January 2016 mission to Tehran was an attempt to build on that by expanding Sino–Iranian cooperation, not least in Xi's Belt and Road project. When it came to saving the JCPOA, however, China had little to offer. Trump's America was waging a trade war with China and viewed China as a strategic competitor.[25] Obama, during the negotiation of the JCPOA, had welcomed China's parallel efforts. Trump, in contrast, saw no reason to listen to Beijing's advice regarding Iran and used trade issues to compel China to cut drastically its purchase of Iranian oil.

It was left to Germany, France, and Britain, which had standing as US allies, to argue with Trump's Washington to save the JCPOA, perhaps by reopening negotiations over items like missiles and regional conflicts not included in the July 2015 document. It was also Europe which felt confident enough to set up a system of international payments for firms to trade with Iran while avoiding the US-controlled payment system. Trump's administration proposed to punish companies that traded with Iran in violation of re-imposed US sanctions. China, struggling to save its own economy from Trump's trade war, dropped Iran from its already long list of conflicts to be raised with Trump's China envoys. European representatives were happy to tell America where it was going wrong with Iran.

Beijing's brief and ill-fated post-JCPOA courtship of Tehran represents some of the limits on China as a major power. Its